Sadat flies to Israel 1977

The bravest peacemaker, however, was undoubtedly President Sadat. He wanted permanent peace because four wars against Israel had cost many lives and devastated the Egyptian economy. Egypt needed a lasting peace in order to recover. In November 1977 he surprised the world by announcing that he was willing to go to Israel and discuss peace. This was a bold move because, for 30 years, no Arab leader had even agreed to recognise Israel's existence. Ten days later he flew to Israel. He spoke to the Israeli parliament:

> We used to reject you, and we had our reasons and grievances. But I say to you today and I say to the whole world that we accept that we should live with you in lasting and just peace.

In his reply, the Israeli Prime Minister said:

> The time of the flight from Cairo to Jerusalem is short but the distance until last night was almost infinite.

The following month the Israeli Prime Minister, Menachem Begin, went to Egypt and peace talks were started. When they slowed down in 1978, US President Carter invited the Egyptian and Israeli leaders to **Camp David** in the USA. For 13 days the three men and their advisers discussed a peace settlement.

Key term
Camp David
The US President's mountain retreat.

Agreement at Camp David 1978

Key question
What were the results of the Camp David meeting?

At Camp David, a framework for peace between Israel and Egypt was agreed. The main points were:

- Israeli forces to be withdrawn from Sinai
- Egypt to regain all of Sinai within three years
- Israeli shipping to have free passage through the Suez Canal and the Straits of Tiran (see the map on page 56).

Key dates
Camp David Agreement between Egypt and Israel: 1978

Treaty of Washington between Egypt and Israel: 1979

The Treaty of Washington 1979

Six months after Camp David, in March 1979, the Egyptian and Israeli leaders signed the Treaty of Washington which confirmed what they had agreed at Camp David. Both sides finally agreed to recognise 'each other's right to live in peace within their secure and recognised boundaries'.

The Israelis felt more secure now that they had traded land for peace and neutralised the biggest Arab military power. Most Egyptians were pleased that Sadat was putting Egypt's interests first: they felt that Egypt had made huge sacrifices in blood and money on behalf of the Arabs. In fact, most of the world applauded this breakthrough in Arab–Israeli relations. But that was not how the rest of the Arab world viewed things: they saw Sadat as breaking Arab ranks. Instead of standing up to Israel